

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Hard Misuse risk: High

CORE FORMULA

Name what the conversation is actually about -> Shift from surface detail to real stakes -> Invite them into the new frame

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

When a conversation is stuck on the wrong thing, say: 'I want to step back — the real question here is...' and name it.

BEST FOR

- Negotiations where both sides are arguing past each other
- Conflicts that are stuck on symptoms rather than causes
- Presentations where the audience is focused on the wrong concern
- Situations where the conversation is at risk of missing what actually matters

PHRASE BANK

Reframe Phrases · Shifting the frame

- "I want to step back for a moment — the real question here is..."
- "I think we may be arguing about the wrong thing."
- "Let me name what I think is actually at stake."
- "If we solve X, we may still have problem Y. The underlying issue is..."
- "We keep coming back to this because the real concern is..."
- "I want to name what I think is actually going on here."
- "The surface question is X — the deeper question is Y."
- "What are we actually trying to solve?"

Invite Into the Frame · Getting them to engage with the reframe

- "Does that land as the real issue for you?"
- "Am I naming the right thing, or is it something else?"
- "I want to make sure I am naming it accurately — what would you add?"
- "Is the real concern X or is it something deeper?"

Reframing Under Fire · Resetting the frame when pressure is high

- "Before we trade another counter-offer — the real negotiation is about risk, not price."
- "We can keep arguing this line item, or we can talk about what is actually blocking the deal."
- "The question this room keeps circling is not the budget. It is whether we still believe in the project."
- "If we get this wrong, the timeline will not be the thing we regret."
- "Let me say what I suspect we are all thinking: this is about trust, not process."

Personal Reframes · Naming what the argument is really about

- "I do not think we are really arguing about the dishes."
- "Can we pause? I think this is about something bigger than tonight."
- "The plans are not the issue, are they? Tell me what is underneath."
- "I keep snapping about small things because there is a big thing I have not said."
- "We are fighting about logistics when I think we are both just scared."
- "Forget the schedule for a second — are we OK?"

Plain Naming · Saying the real stakes without wrapping

- "This is not about the deadline. It is about whether my work is trusted."

- "Let us stop treating this as a process question. It is a people question."
- "The spreadsheet is a proxy — the real disagreement is about strategy."
- "I will say it plainly: what is at stake is the client relationship, not this invoice."
- "We are debating the wording because nobody wants to debate the decision."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Getting deeper and deeper into a detail that does not matter
Better: Can we look at the bigger picture here?
Best: I want to name what I think is actually at stake. Can we check whether we agree on that?
2. Weak: Reframing to avoid a difficult point
Better: I want to make sure we are solving the right problem.
Best: Reframe that points to the actual issue, not away from it.
3. Weak: Presenting a reframe as if it is the only correct view
Better: I think the real issue is...
Best: This is my read of the real issue — does that match yours?

DECISION TREE

If The conversation is stuck on a detail that does not resolve the real issue

Name the real issue. Invite them to confirm whether you have it right.

"I think we keep coming back to this because the real concern is X — is that right?"

If Both sides are entrenched

Name the shared problem before the competing positions.

"I want to step back — what are we both actually trying to achieve here?"

If You reframe and they resist it

Hold the reframe gently rather than forcing it.

"I may have named it wrong — what would you say the real question is?"

If You use reframes to avoid engaging with the actual issue

Do not. This is a misuse. Engage with the issue first.

SCENARIOS

Negotiation stuck on pricing

Name what is really driving the resistance. — "I wonder if the real concern is not the price but the risk. Can we talk about that?"

Team meeting stuck on a procedural debate

Name the outcome everyone wants and redirect. — "We keep coming back to process — the question underneath that is whether we trust each other on this."

Conflict that is circular

Name the pattern itself. — "We keep having this argument, which tells me there is something unresolved underneath it."

Pitch to an audience that is asking the wrong questions

Name what you think their real concern is before answering. — "I think the question behind that question is whether this is worth the risk. Let me address that."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the reframe is dishonest and the actual stakes are as difficult as they appear — manipulation erodes long-term trust.
- When the audience has already processed the full picture and reframing feels like spin.
- In situations requiring direct accountability — reframing can deflect necessary ownership.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the misplaced conversation

Notice one conversation today that seems to be stuck on the wrong thing. Do not intervene yet.

Day 2 — Name the real question

In one conversation, name what you think is actually at stake beneath the surface.

Day 3 — Invite confirmation

After reframing, ask if your read is accurate rather than assuming it is.

Day 4 — Check for misuse

Notice any moment when you used a reframe to dodge an uncomfortable question.

Day 5 — Name the pattern

In a circular conversation, name the fact that it is circular and ask what it is really about.

Day 6 — Full reframe in practice

Use the technique in one high-stakes conversation where the surface discussion is not the real one.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did reframes land well? Were any resisted? Did any feel manipulative?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name the real stakes accurately — not just redirect the conversation?
- Did I invite the other person to confirm whether my reframe was right?
- Was the reframe genuine — not a tactic to avoid the real issue?
- Did I stay engaged with the surface question even as I named the deeper one?
- Did the conversation shift to a more productive level after the reframe?
- Did I avoid reframing so frequently that it lost meaning?
- Did the other person seem relieved or more engaged after the reframe?